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THE FLIP-FLOP

- **The century-old heritage structure of the Osmania General Hospital in Hyderabad faces demolition as part of the plan to expand facilities at the government institute**
- **The previous BRS regime had endorsed this plan even as the Congress had pledged to protect and preserve the historic landmark**
- **But now, the new Congress regime seems to have backtracked on its promise while pushing for the expansion project before the high court, which is hearing a batch of writ petitions on the issue**

expansion. Then, just ahead of the assembly election in November last year, it announced a plan to expand the hospital's capacity from 1,000 to 1,800 beds and introduce new specialties on the 26-acre campus. As part of the plan, it was revealed, new constructions would be taken up, and the heritage building demolished. Back then, the Congress had opposed the move and pledged to protect and preserve the historic landmark. After coming to power, however, it seems to have changed its stance, and is now asserting the urgent need to expand the hospital.

The matter is currently pending before the Telangana High Court. Pointing to the dilapidated condition of the building, advocate general (AG) A. Sudarshan Reddy has submitted that two expert committees of the government—comprising members from the Indian Institute of Technology (IIT) Hyderabad and the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI)—strongly recommended the construction of a new building to replace the ageing structure. The AG made these submissions on January 30, before a division bench of the high court, comprising Chief Justice Alok Aradhe and Justice Anil Kumar Jukanti, which is hearing a batch of writ petitions on the issue.

ONE YEAR SHY OF A CENTURY, THE HERITAGE STRUCTURE—AN EXEMPLAR OF INDO-SARACENIC ARCHITECTURE—WAS KEPT BEREFT OF FUNDS FOR UPKEEP

These petitions have been filed by the alumni of the Osmania Medical College, lawyers, NGOs and other stakeholders. While seeking directions for the state government to construct a new multistoreyed building for OGH, equipped with superspecialty facilities, they contend that the expert committees, while backing the demand for the construction of additional facilities, did not recommend the demolition of the heritage building.

Anuradha Reddy, convenor, INTACH, Hyderabad, puts forth the primary logic: "OGH is integral to Hyderabad's heritage. Using compatible materials to carry out its repairs scientifically will help it last another 100 years or more." She suggests the building be used for housing administrative offices of the hospital or a museum.

It is also worth asking why things were allowed to come to this pass. The heritage building slipped into further neglect only as plans to expand its facilities kept hanging fire. Now, the A. Revanth Reddy-led Congress government is backtracking on its pre-poll promise, something it can ill afford considering that it is eager to sweep the Lok Sabha election later this year. In an attempt to deflect attention, some in the party claim that more than the government, it's the Hyderabad MP, Asaduddin Owaisi, who wants to tear down the heritage structure to build the new hospital. The All India Majlis-e-Ittehadul Muslimeen (AIMIM) president had, in fact, come under fire for saying so earlier.

Even as the matter rests with the courts, the fledgling Congress government will have to decide whether it wants to keep its promise or defer a decision until after the Lok Sabha election. ■